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Mahalakshmi Temple, Kolhapur

Mahalakshmi Temple (also known as **Ambabai Mandir**) is an important Hindu temple dedicated to Goddess Mahalakshmi, who is worshipped by locals as Ambabai. Goddess Mahalakshmi Ambabai is the consort of Lord Vishnu and it is customary among Hindus to visit Tirumala Venkateswara Temple, Kolhapur Mahalakshmi Temple and Padmavathi Temple as a yatra (pilgrimage). It is believed that visiting these temples as a pilgrimage helps achieve moksha (salvation).[1]

Ambabai Temple of Mahalaxmi	
Religion	
Affiliation	Hinduism
District	Kolhapur
Deity	Mahalakshmi
Festivals	Kirnotsav · Rathotsav · Lakshmi Puja · Diwali · Varalakshmi Vratam · Lalita Panchami · Navratri
Governing body	Paschim Maharashtra Devasthan Samiti
Location	
Location	Bhavani Mandap, Mahadwar Road, Kolhapur
State	Maharashtra
Country	India
Location in Maharashtra	
Coordinates	16°42′00″N 74°14′00″E
Architecture	
Style	Hemadpanti architecture

Description

Mounted on a stone platform, the *murti* of the crowned goddess is made of gemstone and weighs about 40 kilograms. The image of Mahalakshmi carved in black stone is 3 feet in height. The Shri Yantra is carved on one of the walls in the temple. A stone lion (the vahana of the goddess), stands behind the statue. The crown contains a five headed snake. Furthermore, she holds a Matulinga fruit, mace, shield and a pānapātra (drinking bowl). In Lakshmi Sahasranama of Skanda Purana, Goddess Lakshmi is praised as "Om Karaveera Nivasiniye Namaha" means "Glory to the Goddess who lives in Karaveera" and as "Om Sesha Vasuki Samsevyaa Namaha" means "Glory to Goddess who is served by Adi Sesha and Vasuki". They are the 119th and 698th names of Lakshmi in Lakshmi Sahasranama. This is also the description mentioned in the Rahasya of Devi Mahatmya.[2] Professor Prabhakar Malshe says, "The name of Karaveera is still locally used to denote the city of Kolhapur".[3] It is considered one of the three and a half Shaktipeetha's in the Shakta tradition.[4]

Creator	Karnadeva, Chalukya Empire
Completed	7th century CE
Website	
www.mahalaxmikolhapur.com (http://www.mahalaxmikolhapur.com/)	

History

According to one account, the temple of the goddess Mahalakshmi was built by the Chalukya king Karnadeva in 634 CE.[5] Another account dates it to the Shilahara period.[6][7]

According to one theory, the temple was originally a Jain shrine.[8][9][10][11] The 12th-century Kannada-language poet Brahma-shiva, who converted from Jainism to Shaivism and then back to Jainism, states the Mahalakshmi temple was originally a Jain temple dedicated to the yakshini Padmāvatī[12][13] or the tirthankara Chandraprabha.[14] Sheshashayee Vishnu temple, whose sanctum has an idol of Vishnu reclining on the serpent Shesha, is an octagonal structure closer to the eastern gate. It has a panel of carvings of 60 Jain tirthankaras, and is believed to have been originally dedicated to the tirthankara Neminath.[15][16]

The 1182 CE inscription of the Shilahara king Bhoja II, preserved at the Hari-Hareshvara shrine within the Mahalakshmi temple premises, states that he obtained a boon from Mahalakshmi. The inscription records king's donations to a Shaivite matha established by a Brahmin named Lokana Nayaka, within the temple premises.[17]

Shri Mahalakshmi Temple, Kolhapur.

The central icon of the goddess

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